

MARKETING & COPY TEARDOWN

acme.example

Proof before promise. Wedge before noise. Clarity before checkout.

A worked **sample** showing the teardown format end to end. The subject — “Acme”, a fictional product analytics SaaS at a reserved .example domain — and every finding below are invented to illustrate the structure. Swap in a real product to use this as a template.

Sample report. Fictional product, invented copy and findings — illustrative only, not based on any real company. Competitor names in `Appendix A` are placeholders.

Your copy is not the problem. The hero line is competent. The problem is that **the copy is doing the wrong job in the wrong order**, on top of an offer that asks for a credit card before it has earned belief, with a pricing page that contradicts itself and the homepage.

01	02	03
Earn belief before asking for the card.	Pick one positioning.	De-confuse the pricing page.
A bold, unbenchmarked accuracy claim, no free trial, and three logos no one recognizes is a credibility gap, not a copy gap. No headline rewrite survives it. Ship a self-serve trial, show the product working, lead with the guarantee.	You are selling “unified analytics” (commoditized — Northstar, Metricly, Funnelhouse own it) when your only defensible wedge is no-instrumentation session capture. Lead with the wedge; demote the dashboard to a proof point.	It is four documents fighting on one page (SaaS price sheet / usage meter / enterprise gate / capability flex). It answers neither question a pricing page exists to answer: what will I pay? and what’s my downside?

This is a copy/positioning critique, not a decision-grade pricing commit, so it deliberately does not prescribe price numbers — a real engagement would have willingness-to-pay evidence; the correct output here is a structure plus a price test, not a price.

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What the product actually is

CATEGORY

Product analytics / session-capture SaaS.

CORE MECHANIC

Drop one snippet on the site. Acme auto-captures every click, route, and form interaction — no manual event tagging — then reconstructs funnels and session replays. Billed per monthly tracked user against a tiered plan.

Differentiators claimed

- Zero-instrumentation capture — “no engineers, no event taxonomy, live in five minutes.”
- Replay + funnels + heatmaps in one tool.
- “Privacy-first”: PII auto-masked, EU data residency on higher tiers.
- “Models accuracy beats the category leaders” — no benchmark cited.

Commercial state

Live and self-serve in theory, but the homepage routes every CTA to **Book a demo**. A 14-day trial exists and is mentioned only on the pricing page. Headline social proof is three unfamiliar logos and one unattributed pull quote. Founder/team page is a single paragraph with no names.

Full sample of the extracted copy is in [Appendix A](#).

RESOLVE THESE OR NO COPY FIX IS RELIABLE

Critical unknowns

At least the first two are validity preconditions — if the assumption is wrong, the entire approach is invalid, not merely sub-optimal.

#	UNKNOWN	WHY IT CAN INVALIDATE EVERYTHING	CHEAPEST WAY TO LEARN
1	PRECONDITION Activation reality. Does the “five-minute, zero-instrumentation” promise actually hold for a real site, or does it need a data layer, a CSP exception, and an engineer?	If setup truly needs engineering, the entire wedge (“no engineers”) is false and every hero variant built on it misleads — churn and refund risk, not just weak conversion.	Install the snippet on three real test sites yourself; time to first usable funnel. Half a day.
2	PRECONDITION Cold-traffic trust floor. Will a cold buyer start a trial for an analytics tool that captures “everything” with no	If no, the blocker is the offer and proof, not the words. Demo-booked leads are sales-warmed and do not predict self-serve conversion (selection bias).	Show the live page to 8 target PMs (or 5 unmoderated tests): “Would you start this trial? What stops you?” \$0–60, 1 day.

	recognizable proof and no named team?		
3	PRECONDITION Privacy claim is real. Is PII masking on by default and contractually backed, or a config flag and a blog post?	“Privacy-first” while capturing all interactions is a legal and trust landmine. If it’s not real and default, the claim must come down before any campaign ships.	Read the masking defaults and DPA; capture a session on a form page and inspect what was stored. 2 hours.
4	ICP ambiguity. Buyer = product managers, growth marketers, or front-end engineers? Each needs a different hero and proof.	Targeting all three converts none.	Read the free-text “what will you use Acme for?” answers already captured at trial signup; skim support tickets for role signals.
5	Flat vs. usage billing. The page says “simple flat plans” and “billed per tracked user, overage \$0.002 each.”	This is the single fact a buyer needs to evaluate the offer. Until resolved, they cannot predict the bill.	One sentence stating the billing rule + one worked invoice example.

WHERE THE MARKETING ACTUALLY BREAKS

§ 03

Diagnosis

3.1 Belief is the dominant constraint, not copy polish

A cold visitor sees **a tool that captures everything, an unbenchmarked “beats the leaders” claim, three unknown logos, no named team, and no way to try it without a sales call.** Every item is individually a small doubt; stacked, they read as “unproven” to anyone who isn’t already a referral.

The page leads with features (the most commoditized story in analytics) and a demo gate (friction before value), while the actual conversion blocker — “is this real, is it safe to point at my users, and will it actually work without an engineer?” — is unaddressed anywhere.

Polishing the headline cannot fix a credibility-architecture problem. The marketing job here is proof engineering; copy is downstream of it.

The demo-only homepage is a self-inflicted wound: every self-serve-inclined visitor who wanted to just try it bounced and never saw the product work. A gated page must still show the product doing its job.

3.2 Positioning is muddled — you’re competing in the wrong lane

Three different products are fighting inside this site:

- 01 **Unified analytics dashboard** — “funnels, retention, dashboards.”
Commoditized; Northstar, Metricly and Funnelhouse own the category and the comparison pages. You will not win here.
- 02 **Session replay tool** — watch real user sessions; a crowded but smaller field.
- 03 **Zero-instrumentation capture** — point it at any site, get analytics with no event taxonomy and no engineering.

(c) is the only defensible wedge — few competitors offer genuinely tag-free capture. Your own onboarding proves it: the “five minutes, no engineers” path is the one thing reviewers consistently praise. Yet the hero leads with (a), the commoditized lane.

3.3 Named dominant alternative + wedge

The buyer’s default is “we already have Northstar” or a free GA property plus a spreadsheet. “We also do funnels” does not move them. The defensible wedge is the combination: **tag-free capture + replay + funnels with zero engineering setup** → “analytics you can install yourself before lunch — no tracking plan, no engineers.”

ONE SENTENCE THAT DOES THE WORK

§ 04

Positioning recommendation

For product and growth teams who can’t get engineering time for a tracking plan, Acme is analytics you install yourself in five minutes — it captures every interaction with no event tagging, so you get funnels and session replay without writing or maintaining instrumentation. Unlike Northstar or a hand-built GA setup, there is nothing to instrument and nothing to keep in sync. It also masks PII by default, so you can point it at production safely.

— THE PITCH

Feature breadth moves from the pitch to a closing proof point.

Homepage copy rewrite

5.1 Hero — the wedge, proof-forward

H1

“Product analytics you install yourself — no tracking plan, no engineers.”

Sub

“Drop one snippet and Acme captures every click and funnel automatically. PII is masked by default. Funnels, retention, and session replay in one tool — live in about five minutes.”

Primary CTA

Start free — no card, no sales call (self-serve trial)

Secondary CTA

Watch a 90-second product tour

DO NOT

Make “Book a demo” the first and only thing a cold visitor can do. Keep the feature-led hero (“All your product analytics in one place”) as the A/B challenger, not the default.

5.2 Section order — the real fix

- 01 **Hero** (above).
- 02 **Live product moment** — an autoplaying 12-second capture-to-funnel clip, or an interactive sandbox. Proof beats promise; this single thing kills the “unproven” read faster than any sentence on the page.
- 03 **“Is it safe to point at production?”** — name the objection out loud, then answer it: default PII masking, DPA, data residency, what is and isn’t stored.
- 04 **Guarantee** — promoted from buried FAQ to a headline block: “Cancel in two clicks, prorated refund, export everything.”
- 05 **How zero-instrumentation works** (one diagram).
- 06 **Funnels / replay / retention** — the feature breadth, now as proof, not pitch.
- 07 **Pricing** (transparent, one default plan; last, not first).
- 08 **Who’s behind this** (named team, changelog, status page).

Never gate the only path behind a demo. A demo CTA can coexist with self-serve — but “Start free” must be the primary action above the fold.

Pricing page — confusion ledger

The pricing page confuses readers because it is simultaneously four incompatible documents, each sabotaging the others:

- 01 A SaaS price sheet (three tiers, per-seat-ish framing).
- 02 A usage meter (per tracked user, overage per event, sampling caveats).
- 03 An enterprise gate (“contact us” for the things buyers actually need).
- 04 A capability flex (an unsourced “2× more accurate than the category leaders”).

Document 2 negates Document 1. Document 3 hides the answer to “what’s my downside?” The page answers neither what will I pay per month? nor what happens when I exceed a limit?

6.1 Confusion ledger — every contradiction, named

CONFUSION	EXACT CONFLICTING COPY	WHY IT BREAKS THE BUYER
Flat vs. usage	“simple flat plans” + “billed per tracked user, \$0.002 / extra event”	Opposite billing models in one phrase. Buyer can’t predict spend.
Cross-page price mismatch	Home “from \$49/mo” vs pricing “Starter \$79/mo”	Two headline prices contradict between pages seen in one session. Reads as bait.
“Unlimited” that isn’t	“unlimited sessions” + “fair-use sampling above 100k/mo”	A carve-out on an “unlimited” claim. Under-disclosed; erodes trust on the page where trust matters most.
Plan vs. add-on sprawl	3 tiers + replay add-on + residency add-on + seats + events	5 orthogonal billing axes. Needs a spreadsheet. Conversion killer.
Accuracy figure drifts	hero “2× more accurate” / FAQ “up to 40% fewer blind spots”	No single credible number; reads as marketing math.
Unsourced benchmark	“beats the category leaders” with no method, no source	Strong claim, no evidence. On a trust-fragile page, unsourced flexes reduce credibility.
Hidden enterprise wall	“SSO, DPA, residency: contact sales”	The things a serious buyer must have are exactly the things behind a gate. Stalls evaluation.
Trial terms unclear	“14-day trial” but card required and auto-converts	A “free trial” that bills silently on day 15 is a refund and chargeback engine.
Seat math undefined	“per editor” but viewers/“contributors” undefined	Buyer can’t compute team cost. Procurement stalls.
Annual lock framing	“save 20% annual” shown as the only price	Monthly price hidden makes the entry cost feel higher than it is.

6.2 What a fixed pricing page looks like — structure, not numbers

No price numbers are prescribed here: a real engagement would set them from willingness-to-pay evidence; the correct output is a structure plus a price test, not a number.

- 01 **One sentence at the top declaring the model:** “You pay per tracked user. Here is the rule and a worked example.” Pick one model. Never show two.
- 02 **One value metric, one default plan.** Lead with a single blended price stated as a ceiling (“you never pay more than \$X / 1k tracked users”). Push tiers behind a “Need volume or SSO? →” link. Max three plans visible.
- 03 **A cost calculator, not a static tier table.** Input: monthly tracked users. Output: your bill here vs. the obvious alternative.
- 04 **An honest downside box, stated by you before the buyer finds it.** “Over your plan? You’re sampled, not surprise-billed — here’s exactly when.”
- 05 **Free trial with no card**, or say plainly “card required, cancel anytime, we email before we bill.” Owning this builds trust; hiding it destroys it.
- 06 **Kill the accuracy claim or cite it** with a defined, reproducible benchmark.

HIGHEST LEVERAGE, RANKED

§ 07

Trust-fix checklist

- 01 **Ship a no-card self-serve trial (or an interactive sandbox) before any demo ask.** Usable proof beats all copy.
- 02 **Make the team legible.** Real names, faces, a public changelog and status page. “Unproven” dies when the page shows people and momentum.
- 03 **Lead with the guarantee, not the feature list.**
- 04 **Make the privacy claim true and default**, then say so on the homepage, not only in a buried FAQ.
- 05 **Replace the three unknown logos** with one concrete, attributed result (“Team X cut analytics setup from 3 weeks to a day”).
- 06 **Put a real product moment above the fold** — autoplaying capture-to-funnel clip or sandbox.
- 07 **Commit to one ICP** (unknown #4) and cut the other two heroes’ worth of mixed signals.
- 08 **Make the homepage and pricing page agree on every number** — single source of truth.

FOUNDER-EXECUTABLE, THIS WEEK

§ 08

Next actions

- 01 Decide flat vs. usage billing; write the one-sentence rule + one worked invoice (unknown #5).
- 02 Install the snippet on three real sites yourself; document true time-to-value (unknown #1).
- 03 Make homepage and pricing agree on every number — single source of truth (cross-page mismatch).
- 04 Stand up the no-card trial or an interactive sandbox (highest single ROI).

- 05 Run the 8-PM / 5-unmoderated-test “would you start this trial, what stops you?” probe (unknown #2).
- 06 Read existing trial-signup free-text answers; classify the real ICP (unknown #4).
- 07 Reorder the homepage per §5.2; collapse pricing to ≤ 3 visible plans; add the cost calculator and the honest overage box.
- 08 Run a Van Westendorp / Gabor-Granger WTP probe with target buyers **before** finalizing any price number.

WHEN THE DIAGNOSIS IS WRONG

§ 09

Kill / pivot / narrow rules

Belief model.

After shipping the no-card trial + legible team + guarantee-forward copy, if cold-traffic qualitative still fails — **<3 of 8 target PMs say they'd start the trial**, with “don't trust capturing everything / don't believe the accuracy claim / can't tell what I'd pay” as the dominant objection — the blocker is the offer and proof model itself, not the copy. **Pivot:** lead with a free, capped, no-account sandbox tier, **or narrow hard** to the no-instrumentation segment and stop pitching general analytics buyers.

Offer architecture.

After de-confusing the pricing page, if $\geq$ half of probe respondents still say “I can't tell what I'd pay” or “the overage thing makes it feel risky,” the per-tracked-user metered model is unsellable to cold buyers. **Pivot** to a flat, predictable plan with a generous cap, or narrow to the segment whose volume is stable enough to tolerate metering.

APPENDIX A

Sample extracted copy

fictional — illustrative only

A.1 Homepage

- **Hero H1:** “All your product analytics in one place.”
- **Sub:** “Funnels, retention, dashboards, and session replay — without the spreadsheet.”
- **CTAs:** “Book a demo” (×3), “Talk to sales”, “See plans”.
- **Social proof:** three unfamiliar logos; one unattributed quote (“It changed how we work.”).
- **Benefits:** Auto-capture; Funnels; Retention; Heatmaps; Replay; “Privacy-first”.
- **Team:** one paragraph, no names; no changelog or status link.

A.2 Pricing page (sample)

- **Tiers:** Starter “\$79/mo”; Growth “\$249/mo”; Scale “contact sales”.
- **Meter:** “billed per tracked user; \$0.002 per extra event; fair-use sampling above 100k sessions/mo”.
- **Trial:** “14-day free trial” (card required; auto-converts).
- **Add-ons:** session replay; EU data residency; SSO/DPA “contact sales”.
- **Flex:** “2× more accurate than the category leaders” (no method, no source).

A.3 Competitor names used above

- “Northstar”, “Metricly”, “Funnelhouse”, “Replaylab” are **invented placeholders** for this sample and do not refer to real companies.

APPENDIX B

Notes on this sample

- This is a **sample** report shipped with the template. The product, the copy, the findings, the numbers and the competitor names are all **fictional** and exist only to exercise every block type (key-value list, ordered/unordered lists, tables with tags, callouts, pull quotes, definition rules, appendices).
- The subject domain uses the reserved `.example` TLD specifically so it cannot be mistaken for a real site.
- To use this as a real teardown, replace the data in `report.type` with real, sourced findings and keep an honest evidence/citation note here in its place.
- No real sources were consulted; nothing here should be cited or relied upon.